

# CLARA (YEHYUN) KYUNG

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## Office Contact Information

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Saieh Hall for Economics  
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## Education

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**University of Chicago**, Ph.D. Economics (expected June 2026) *2020–present*

**McGill University**, B.A. Economics with minors in Finance and Mathematics *2015–2019*

## References

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Professor Derek Neal (Chair)  
University of Chicago  
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Professor Evan Rose  
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Professor Jack Mountjoy  
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Booth School of Business  
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## Research and Teaching Fields

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Primary: Labor, Education  
Secondary: Applied Microeconomics, Industrial Organization

## Job Market Paper

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### Resources or Rewards? The Impacts of School District Funding and Incentives on Student Outcomes (with Haruka Uchida)

*Abstract: School funding and accountability are prevalent policy tools in public education, but their efficacy in improving student outcomes remains contested. We study the impacts of a statewide education reform in Texas that (1) changed the formula that links school district characteristics to funding, and, in a novel shift from test-based accountability, (2) introduced financial bonuses for districts based on high school graduates' attainment outcomes, including college enrollment and industry-based certification. Using policy-driven, between-district variation in district spending and incentives, we find that both spending and incentives improved the composite attainment outcome targeted by the bonus policy. Relative to funding increases, incentives produced comparable gains at a lower government cost. Effects on attainment are driven by industry-based certifications, with little effect on college enrollment. However, by focusing on high school graduates' outcomes, the bonus structure incentivized districts to*

reduce graduation rates among 12th graders who were unlikely to meet the attainment criteria: we indeed find that incentives decreased graduation rates and increased dropout rates. Consequently, we find mixed evidence on college and career outcomes one year after 12th grade: neither district spending nor incentives affected the share of students who were employed or enrolled in college, but both increased earnings. Our results highlight both the potential promise and design challenges of attainment-based incentive policies.

## Work in Progress

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### Outside Opportunities and Teacher Attrition

*Abstract: This paper investigates the impact of outside labor market opportunities on teacher attrition separately for teachers trained through traditional vs alternative certification pathways. To combat teacher shortages, the majority of states have developed alternative teacher certification pathways, which allow individuals who did not receive education training in college to become certified to teach. While training teachers through alternative pathways can increase the supply of teachers, past work has shown that teachers with an alternative certification have higher attrition rates than teachers with a traditional certification. Consequently, expanding alternative certification without addressing attrition fails to deliver a viable long-term solution. This project addresses a hypothesized key driver of this attrition: outside (i.e., non-teaching) labor market opportunities. While past studies document that outside opportunities impact teacher attrition, they do not distinguish between certification pathways. Using hazard models applied to Texas administrative teacher-level data, I estimate the impact of outside labor market opportunities on teacher attrition separately for teachers trained in traditional vs alternative certification pathways. To assess the implications for student outcomes, I investigate the types of teachers (i.e., those with high vs low value-added, those certified to teach certain subjects) who leave when they have better outside opportunities.*

## Awards, Scholarships, and Grants

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|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| Margaret G. Reid Fellowship                                                                | 2025–2026 |
| University of Chicago Data Acquisition Grant (\$3,000)                                     | 2025      |
| University of Chicago Social Sciences Division Fellowship                                  | 2020–2025 |
| Becker-Friedman Institute Public Economics Initiative Grant (with Haruka Uchida) (\$5,000) | 2024      |
| McGill University Allen Oliver Gold Medal                                                  | 2019      |

## Teaching Experience

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|----------------------------------------------|-------------------------|-------------------|
| Industrial Organization (undergraduate)      | TA for Prof. Dinerstein | Spring 2023, 2024 |
| Introduction to Econometrics (undergraduate) | TA for Prof. Hardwick   | Fall 2023         |
| Job Mobility/Wage Determinants (graduate)    | TA for Prof. Neal       | Fall 2022         |
| Economics of Education (undergraduate)       | TA for Prof. Neal       | Fall 2021         |

## Pedagogical Training

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|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|
| College Teaching Certificate, Chicago Center for Teaching and Learning       | 2025 |
| Course Design and College Teaching, Chicago Center for Teaching and Learning | 2024 |
| Craft of Teaching Series, University of Chicago Divinity School              | 2023 |

## Research Experience and Other Employment

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|----------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| Research Assistant for Prof. Neal, University of Chicago       | 2022–2023 |
| Research Assistant for Prof. Dinerstein, University of Chicago | 2022–2023 |
| Research Assistant, Bank of Canada                             | 2019–2020 |

## Professional Experience

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| <b>Presentations</b> | <i>University of Chicago Public Labor Lunch, University of Chicago Student Applied Micro Lunch</i> |
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## Additional Information

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| <b>Citizenship</b> | Canada |
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| <b>Programming Skills</b> | Stata, MATLAB, Julia, Python, L <sup>A</sup> T <sub>E</sub> X |
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| <b>Languages</b> | English (Native), French (Fluent), Korean (heritage speaker), Spanish (elementary) |
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